Islam Creates the Balkans

With the Ottoman conquest of Byzantium (Constantinople) in 1453, the lands that once marked the dividing line between the Western and Eastern Roman Empires and later between the Franks and the Greeks were turned into a buffer zone between the Ottoman Empire and the Holy Roman Empire. Although at one point the Ottomans made it as far as Vienna, they never permanently settled west of this East-West divide. The fall of Constantinople as the capital of an already fading Eastern Empire seemed to make it easy for the Ottomans to conquer the rest of that empire. On the other hand, Western Europe pulled itself together to establish a more coordinated and effective defence against the Ottomans and did not allow them to progress further west.

Europe, as shaped by the Ottoman invasion, then remained almost the same until the nineteenth century. The establishment of ‘Turkey in Europe’, as the Ottoman-occupied zones were known and, on the other side of the divide, the rise of the Habsburg Empire in Central Europe, effectively separated Eastern Europe into three tiers:

- The Balkans (south-east Europe) which was occupied by the Turks and consisted of modern-day Greece, Bulgaria, Serbia, Montenegro, Bosnia, Albania, North Macedonia, parts of Romania and parts of what was then Hungary
- Central Europe and the Baltic shores (i.e. Eastern Europeans within the Habsburg or German Empire) which consisted of the modern-day Czech Republic, Poland, Slovakia, Slovenia, Hungary, the shores of the Baltic states, parts of modern day Romania and most of Croatia
- Eastern Europe ‘proper’ (i.e. the part of Eastern Europe that remained under the more or less strong influence of Russia and is largely Orthodox) which was made up of modern-day Belarus, Ukraine, parts of Poland, Romania, Moldova and parts of the Baltics.

As we can see, there was (and still is today) a degree of overlap. Parts of Poland and the Baltic states, though generally Catholic or Protestant, also experienced some influence from Russian Orthodoxy. Further south, the